



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: American Heritage Academy
School Website: <https://ahav.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Classicality Audit: Hillsdale Academy

School website audited: <https://academy.hillsdale.edu>

Executive Summary

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

Hillsdale Academy presents exceptionally strong alignment to the six essential elements of a classical school. Its public materials explicitly affirm transcendental moral realism ("objective standards of truth, goodness, and beauty"), theological grounding (Christian mission and worship practices), and a liberal arts curriculum centered on Latin, logic, rhetoric, and the Western tradition. Pedagogy references Socratic dialogue, memory and recitation, and culminating public orations/defenses. Faculty are described as moral and intellectual models and mentors, and the school clearly states a partnership with parents as primary educators. Key strengths include: explicit TGB language; required Latin; logic and rhetoric; chapel and communal prayer; Socratic dialogue and public defenses; "virtue and wisdom" as telos; and parent partnership. Minor gaps include limited explicit use of scholé/restful-learning language and limited explicit mention of lower school chanting in classroom pedagogy. These do not materially diminish the overall classical alignment, which is clear and comprehensive.

Evidence highlights: - "Objective standards of truth, goodness, and beauty" and Christian faith commitments (mission, chapel, prayer)

- Required Latin; logic and rhetoric; "Socratic dialogue" and primary sources; great conversation; public thesis defense

- Portrait of a Graduate emphasizes virtue, wonder, intellectual humility, memorization, and pursuit of the True, Good, and Beautiful - Faculty portrayed as mentors and models; explicit parent partnership ("parents are the primary educators")

Reference frameworks used for keyword analysis and scoring: - Six Essential Elements of a Classical School: Positive/Negative Keyword Indicators and category definitions

- Classicality Lexicon (v2.2) for cross-checking signals across all six elements

CATEGORY 1: RELIGIOUS AND METAPHYSICAL FOUNDATIONS

What the site says (keywords/phrases found): - "Objective standards of truth, goodness, and beauty" (truth, goodness, beauty) - Christian/Christian faith; "course of study and instruction guided by the immemorial teachings and practices of the Christian faith" (theology) - "Lord's Prayer," "corporate prayer," weekly "chapel service" (liturgy/communal worship) - "Virtue and wisdom" (motto *virtus et sapientia*)

Match to Six Elements positive indicators: - Transcendental Moral Realism: truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, wisdom (positive)

- Grounded in Theology: Christian, faith, theological integration (positive) - Liturgical/Communal: chapel, prayer (positive)

Negative indicators: none detected (e.g., “values□neutral,” “secular,” “religiously neutral” are absent)

Counts and percentages: - Positive keyword hits: +9 (truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, wisdom, Christian/Christian faith, chapel, prayer, motto) / Negative hits: -0 - Positive ratio: 100% (9/9) - Coverage of sub□criteria: 3/3 = 100% (moral realism, theology, liturgy)

Rating: CLASSICAL

CATEGORY 2: SCHOOL PURPOSE AND GOAL

What the site says (keywords/phrases found): - “Cultivate Christian classical virtue and wisdom” (virtue, wisdom) - “Education is about more than just preparing for college or getting a good job” (formation, not merely utility) - “Pursue the Good, the True, and the Beautiful” (TGB) - “Be lifelong lovers of learning,” “wonder,” “intellectual humility” (formation of mind and affections)

Match to Six Elements positive indicators: - Cultivation of wisdom and virtue; pursuit of truth, goodness, beauty; formation > information (positive)

Negative indicators: explicitly rejected (“more than... getting a good job” counters workforce□first aims) ; no “college-and-career-ready” framing detected

Counts and percentages: - Positive keyword hits: +10 / Negative hits: -0 - Positive ratio: 100% - Coverage of sub□criteria: 3/3 = 100%

Rating: CLASSICAL

CATEGORY 3: SCHOOL CURRICULUM

What the site says (keywords/phrases found): - “Traditional, classical liberal arts education,” Latin required (Trivium emphasis) - “Rhetoric, logic,” “primary sources,” “great conversation,” “Western tradition” - Studies include “history” (not “social studies”), literature, mathematics, science, fine arts, music; senior capstone (humanities thesis) with public defense

Match to Six Elements positive indicators: - Seven Liberal Arts; Great Books/primary sources; historical engagement/Western canon; integration and wonder (positive) - Wonder also explicitly present in profile/philosophy language

Negative indicators: none detected (no “social studies” substitution, “21st□century skills,” STEM□first, or “project□based dominance”)

Counts and percentages: - Positive keyword hits: +9 (liberal arts, Latin, logic, rhetoric, primary sources, great conversation, Western tradition, history, music/arts) / Negative hits: -0 - Positive ratio: 100% - Coverage of sub□criteria: 3/4 = 75% (Trivium/Quadrivium present via Latin/logic/rhetoric/music; Great Books/primary sources; wonder present; explicit “integrated/harmony” phrasing is implied but not strongly asserted)

Rating: CLASSICAL

CATEGORY 4: SCHOOL PEDAGOGY OR TEACHING METHODS

What the site says (keywords/phrases found): - “Socratic dialogue” in upper school/advanced work; seminars and debate implied via thesis defense and public presentation (rhetoric) - “Student recitations,” “store-

house of memorized Scripture, poetry, speeches, and drama" (memorization & recitation)
- Choir and music (supportive of chant/singing culture, although not explicitly lower□school chanting in class)

Match to Six Elements positive indicators: - Socratic dialogue and dialectic; memorization and recitation; rhetoric/orations (positive)

Negative indicators: none detected (no "project□based dominance," "student□directed" buzzwords; "teacher□led" is present but coexists with Socratic)

Counts and percentages: - Positive keyword hits: +4 (Socratic dialogue, recitation, memorization, public defense/orations) / Negative hits: -0 - Positive ratio: 100% - Coverage of sub□criteria: 3/4 = 75% (restful learning/scholé not explicitly named on site; lower□school chanting in class not explicit)

Rating: CLASSICAL

CATEGORY 5: SCHOOL FACULTY

What the site says (keywords/phrases found): - "Well□educated and articulate faculty," "spiritual mentors," "model and lead... toward intellectual, moral, and civic virtue," "stewards of the Christian classical tradition" (teachers as models of virtue) - Ongoing mentorship culture (College apprenticeships with Academy faculty) indicates collegiality and mentoring ethos

Match to Six Elements positive indicators: - Teachers as models of virtue; mentorship and collegiality (positive)

Negative indicators: none detected (no "facilitators/guides□on□the□side" emphasis divorced from formation)

Counts and percentages: - Positive keyword hits: +4 / Negative hits: -0 - Positive ratio: 100% - Coverage of sub□criteria: 2/2 = 100%

Rating: CLASSICAL

CATEGORY 6: SCHOOL PARENTS AND COMMUNITY

What the site says (keywords/phrases found): - "Parents are the primary educators... staff and faculty partner with parents" (partnership with families) - Formation of affections implied via Portrait of a Graduate ("Pursue the Good, the True, and the Beautiful," "approach the world with a sense of wonder") - Communal religious life (daily prayer, weekly chapel) supports shared community ethos; explicit "parents welcome any time" language not found

Match to Six Elements positive indicators: - Partnership with families; formation of affections (positive)

Negative indicators: none detected (no "minimal parent involvement" or "parent as customer" stance)

Counts and percentages: - Positive keyword hits: +2 (parent partnership; formation of affections via love of TGB and wonder) / Negative hits: -0 - Positive ratio: 100% - Coverage of sub□criteria: 2/3 ≈ 67% (no explicit parent education program cited on site pages crawled)

Rating: CLASSICAL

Aggregate Assessment

- Category ratings: C1 CLASSICAL; C2 CLASSICAL; C3 CLASSICAL; C4 CLASSICAL; C5 CLASSICAL; C6 CLASSICAL

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- Overall: CLASSICAL

Rationale: The school explicitly matches the positive keyword indicators across all six elements from the “Six Essential Elements” framework and avoids negative indicators. The presence of TGB language, prayer/chapel, required Latin, logic and rhetoric, Socratic dialogue, memory and recitation, public orations, and clear parent partnership strongly substantiate this rating .

Evidence Appendix (select quotations)

- “An approach to instruction that acknowledges objective standards of truth, goodness, and beauty.”
 - “As a part of Hillsdale College, the Academy is a Christian institution... Lord's Prayer... corporate prayer... chapel service.”
 - “The study of Latin as a requirement for all students... logic... rhetoric... Socratic dialogue and primary sources... humanities thesis... public presentation and defense.”
 - “At the Academy, we believe parents are the primary educators... The staff and faculty partner with parents.”
 - “Pursue the Good, the True, and the Beautiful... Approach the world with a sense of wonder... Have a storehouse of memorized Scripture, poetry, speeches, and drama.”
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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